Revision Cover Letter

Dear future students of Everyday Feminisms, I made significant revisions on this essay, so much so, that it looks completely different from my previous one. I consider this a testament to "good writing requires good thinking." Thinking is a process, a constant back and forth, so don't be surprised to come back to the essay you were once satisfied with only to discover that your thoughts on it have completely changed. My greatest advice is to start thinking early.

Even if you're super busy and can't sit down to write, think about your essay all the time. Think about it during dinner, while showering, right before you go to sleep: don't think about it in a "I'm so stressed and I'm procrastinating" type of way, but rather, "Would someone who doesn't have TikTok understand the vibe I'm trying to communicate" type of way. I believe I've improved drastically in my writing, still not the best, but this is satisfactory for me. I also greatly expanded my knowledge on popular feminism. The unit involving Mulvey and hooks shifted my perspective completely in an uncomfortable, but much-needed, direction. I still have a lot to work on and I'm sure my final essay reflects that. Analysis and structure are the bane of my existence, but I've realized that cultivating these skills has also improved my ability to communicate my thoughts in other mediums. If you're struggling to come up with a topic for your final paper, watch video essays on YouTube. There are a lot of very great and very bad thinkers on there, pick one and fight them. I HIGHLY recommend the writing center and Barker Cafe; the two of them together are essential. First, you go to the writing center and get your essay brutally dissected, and then you go to the cafe upstairs, use your BoardPlus to get some coffee, and fix everything. Overall, this class has been very enjoyable; I will probably think about the male gaze for the rest of my life, but at least I know how to reverse outline an essay!

"I affirm my awareness of the standards of the Harvard College Honor Code." NY

Busra Nimet Yesil

Expos 20: Everyday Feminisms

Dr. Gold

December 5, 2023

BOOK RECS for the GIRLIES going thru it: Dissociative Feminism on #BookTok

BookTok: an online platform where you can let everyone know what book you're reading and also how cute you look while reading it! Perhaps you prefer romance fantasy where the protagonist is a badass woman who doesn't need a man (but falls in love anyway!), or maybe dramatic period pieces full of sexual tension and lengthy dialogues are more to your taste. Or, perhaps, you're a little more esoteric: a connoisseur of books following the existentialist monologues of vaguely amoral and immensely apathetic beautiful upper-class white women: a literary genre without a name but with a shockingly wide range of readers and dedicated community on BookTok. Members of this community can be identified by their distinctly similar TikToks: shuffling through a meticulously-curated stack of apathetic literature to a backdrop of a melancholic audio. These series of online videos consistently idealize female protagonists who have the privilege to dissociate and establish apathetic literature like *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* as a hallmark of their female community. This niche BookTok community finds its origins in a unique feminist movement. As Emmeline Clein highlights in her article The Smartest Women I Know Are All Dissociating, "[women] now seem to be interiorizing our existentialist aches and angst, smirking knowingly at them, and numbing ourselves to maintain our nonchalance. Let's call it dissociative feminism" (Clein par.2). In turn, its members establish the literature of this feminist movement.

The dissociative feminist community on BookTok is mainly geared toward women readers tired of the hyper-feminist expectations of the *girlboss* which is perpetuated by what Sarah Banet-Weiser calls “popular feminism” and what is present on BookTok through popular feminist literature. BookTok has only exacerbated the diffusion and popularity of dissociative feminist literature as a counter literary tradition to popular feminist literature, providing a community for women readers tired of the shortcomings of popular feminist literature. Yet, dissociative feminism may not be the reprieve it is illustrated to be and coupled with BookTok’s perpetuation, BookTok may be harming feminism. BookTok is a platform that promotes dissociative feminist literature as what Pierre Bordieu calls “cultural capital,” ~~defined by Pierre Bourdieu’s *Theory of Cultural Reproduction and Social Reproduction*, thereby~~ establishing a community of women readers who form an identity centered around apathy toward the patriarchy and other female issues. This leads to the proliferation of literature that gives voice to women who have the privilege to dissociate and their apathetic woes with the patriarchy, promoting a (exclusionary?) feminist stance that is inherently damaging to the collective feminist movement.

Utilizing a particular order’s (e.g niche BookTok community) cultural capital to signal association culminates in the formation of an identity that perpetuates the dominion of that particular order. In his renowned *Theory of Cultural Reproduction and Social Reproduction*, esteemed French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu states “the task of legitimating the established order does not fall exclusively to the mechanisms traditionally regarded as belonging to the order of ideology, such as law” (Bourdieu 188). For example, in the context of social hierarchy, the privilege associated with the domination of the upper class ~~isn’t~~ iis not maintained solely through economic, educational, or political ecosystems. Instead, the persistence of this class dominion

can be attributed to symbols, or what Bourdieu fittingly labels *cultural capital*. Regarding the development of identity, Bourdieu claims that cultural capital can maintain the order, without the conscious efforts of the individual, “Objectification guarantees the permanence and cumulativity of material and symbolic acquisitions which can then subsist without the agents having to recreate them continuously” (197) and cultural capital creates a relation between the agent and the order which also doesn’t need to be developed because of its identificatory nature, “objectification also and inseparably ensures the reproduction of the structure of the distribution of the capital, and in so doing, reproduces the structure of the relations of domination and dependence” (197). Additionally, Bourdieu’s claim can be applied in more contemporary orders like BookTok: a platform on the audio-centric social media app TikTok for users to share videos centered on books like videos on book recommendations and book reviews. Communities on BookTok would define their order through their cultural capital (e.g audio, literature). Furthermore, Bourdieu expands on his argument by elaborating on the role symbolic goods play in the perpetuation of specific orders~~,“~~, noting: “The system of symbolic goods production and the system producing the producers fulfill in addition i.e by the very logic of their normal functioning, ideological functions, by virtue of the fact that the mechanisms through which they contribute to the reproduction of the established order and to perpetuation of dominion remain hidden” (Bourdieu 188). Likewise, a niche BookTok community aligned with a particular ideology like feminism might develop a certain set of literature, cultural capital, for its members to visibly associate with via TikToks and idealize.

Mainstream BookTok makes popular feminism “visible” through *girlboss* cultural capitals. BookTok, like most media, is a platform for the diffusion and perpetuation of ideologies like feminism and due to the visibility-centered nature of TikTok, its videos need to be short and

visually and audibly appealing—in short, consumable. Meaning that feminism on mainstream BookTok needs to be distilled in order to stay relevant. In her book *Empowered: Popular Feminism and Popular Misogyny*, Sarah ~~Benet~~Banet-Weiser defines popular feminism as a feminism that "manifests in discourses and practices that are circulated in popular and commercial media, such as digital spaces…[with] an accessibility that is not confined to academic enclaves or niche groups." (Benet-Weiser 1). The feminism on mainstream BookTok both manifests in popular media and is accessible to the masses. As such, the feminism of mainstream BookTok can be defined as popular feminism. Through the utilization of *girlboss*, or the idea that women are….., mainstream BookTok makes popular feminism visible. In a TikTok video captioned "BOOKS with a GIRL BOSS MAIN CHARACTER" by @itssadieg, the user shuffles through a stack of books (a trademark BookTok video setup) while an incessant audio mash of a clip from a Cher interview and *Boss Bitch* by Doja Cat plays in the background. All of the books shuffled through are revered for their *girlboss* protagonist, a term never explicitly defined, but implicitly clarified through the video's *girlboss* audio: "My mom said to me, you know sweetheart, one day you should settle down and marry a rich man, and I said mom, I am the rich man." This Cher audio encouraging female independence has gone viral with ninety-one thousand videos using it for videos on feminism, establishing it as a widely-accepted feminist mantra on TikTok. Additionally, *Boss Bitch*, through its persistent repetition of "I'm a bitch, I'm a boss, I'm a bitch and a boss, I'ma shine like gloss," perfectly captures the quintessence of the *girlboss*, a woman who is a boss, in other words, powerful, and shows it off, making her *girlboss* visible to those around her. Accordingly, the audio elucidates *girlboss* as a visible independent powerful feminist, aligning with Weiser's definition of popular feminism by manifesting in media and being an identity marketed to the masses. The literature of the BookTok video is

cultural capital and by describing them as *girlboss* they are associated with the order of popular feminism. Through Bourdieu's rhetoric, popular feminism's cultural capital, popular feminist literature and audios, establishes an identity of the *girlboss*, which can then be attributed to characters, individuals etc. This BookTok video makes popular feminism visible. And there are a thousand more videos just like it on BookTok.

Mainstream BookTok and its popular feminism are harmful to the collective feminist movement because it encourages a one-dimensional *consumable* caricature of feminism focused on visibility, ~~*girlboss,*~~ rather than actively furthering the collective cause. As Benet-Wesier sarcastically puts it, "Women just have to be a GirlBoss or Lean In in order to overcome sexist history." (19). The identity of the *girlboss* is like a bandaid over a bullet wound; becoming independent and powerful in any sense will not change the fact that women remain underprivileged due to patriarchy. Additionally, there is a limit to how *girlboss* a character can be, so eventually its literature follows the same pattern, making it predictable, one-dimensional, and overall, un-appealing. As a result, the popular feminism on mainstream BookTok alienates many women due to its one-dimensionality. Furthermore, due to popular feminism's desire for and reliance on visibility, its feminism is inherently misguided. Building on this point, Benet-Weiser establishes, "The visibility of popular feminism, where examples appear on television, in film, on social media, and on bodies, is important, but it often stops there, as if seeing or purchasing feminism is the same thing as changing patriarchal structures" (Benet-Weiser 4). The visibility economy, which Benet-Weiser defines as a system that prioritizes quantifiable goals like likes, views, shares, etc. is the foundation of popular feminism, dictating the motives of popular feminism, and as a result, finding purpose in a goal other than the benefit of women, which is counterproductive and harmful. Coupled with the visibility-driven nature of BookTok,

the feminism present on mainstream BookTok needs to become ever more consumable and distilled to stay visible. *Girlboss* prevents feminist progress because it roots its purpose in visibility rather than empowerment.

To combat popular feminism's shortcomings, a counter-tradition has emerged on niche BookTok: dissociative feminism. Dissociation is a medical term mainly used in psychiatric settings. The Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, fifth edition, describes it as "a disruption, interruption, and/or discontinuity of the normal subjective integration of behavior, memory, identity, consciousness, emotion, perception, body representation, and motor control" (American Psychiatric Association, 2013). Dissociation is rooted in apathy and escapism, making it a fitting juxtaposition to the obnoxiously performative nature of popular feminism. As such, dissociative feminism can be defined as a movement of women who take an apathetic stance to their problems, whether that be personal or political, seeking the privileged identity behind dissociation instead of the high standards of independence and power associated with the identity of the *girlboss*. In her Buzzfeed article *The Smartest Women I Know Are All Dissociating*, Emmeline Clein states, "I've noticed a lot of brilliant women giving up on shouting and complaining, and instead taking on a darkly comic, deadpan tone when writing about their feminism. This approach presents overtly horrifying facts about uniquely feminine struggles and delivers them flatly, dripping with sarcasm" (Clein par.2). Dissociative feminism exists outside of BookTok, but has been appropriated and refined by BookTok users utilizing it as a counter tradition ideology for their niche community. In turn, these niche BookTok users are the ones establishing the cultural capital of dissociative feminism, dissociative feminist literature.

Dissociative feminism can be identified on BookTok through its cultural capitals, dissociative feminist literature and symbolic audios. In a TikTok video captioned "'i can fix her.'

her: #booktok" by @lizcastro3110, *Shades of Blue* by Lana Del Ray plays in the background as the user dismissively pushes aside prescription medicine and lipstick to shuffle through a stack of books with titles ranging from *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* by Otessa Moshfegh and *Normal People* by Sally Rooney. The melancholic lyrics "He lives for love, he loves his drugs, he loves his baby too, but I can't fix him, can't make him better." coupled with the video's caption "'i can fix her.' her:" posits the unidentified women, "her", as someone unfixable that "can't [be made] better." Additionally, through the open colon left at the end of the caption, the user is establishing the literature that she shuffles through as identificatory: these books are for unfixable women, an identity the user clearly identifies with, yet, elucidated by her apathetic attitude to the prescription medicine and lipstick, she doesn't care that she is unfixable. Overall, this BookTok establishes a feeling of dissociation, a video of someone who acknowledges issues, but dismisses them anyway. Additionally, one of the books highlighted in the video is a piece of apathetic literature that has been adopted by the dissociative feminist BookTok community: *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*. It features a conventionally-attractive upper class white female protagonist who is trying to sleep for an entire year to avoid her problems. Not only is the protagonist's entire rhetoric dissociative in nature, her unadmirable disordered character lies in direct contrast to the identity of the *girlboss*, setting her and the book up as a counter tradition. As a result, users on BookTok show it off to display their association with the apathy on female issues aligning with the ideology of dissociative feminism. The protagonist acknowledges sexism, her mental issues, and various other problems, but instead of actively solving them, she attempts to medicate herself into a year-long coma, dissociating away.

Apathy in literature can be useful in highlighting the pitfalls of unproductive systems. As Sofie Behluli establishes in her paper *On Literary Apathy: Forms of Dis/Affection in My Year of*

Rest and Relaxation, there's a tradition in American literature that appeals to apathy, countering the strong evocative feelings emblematic of typical American literature. Behluli clarifies her definition of apathy as "an umbrella term to express a mode of withdrawal and disengagement" (Behluli 6) and examines *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* by Otessa Moshfegh, which Behluli claims "invites readers to rethink apathy not just as an inevitable consequence of a broken system but also as a chance to step outside the affective structures of care that sustain the system" (Behluli 2). In other words, Moshfegh's apathetic novel explores personal and political apathy, establishing the beautiful depressed rich white protagonist trying to medicate herself into a year-long coma as a mode to highlight the inherent problems of a flawed structure, highlighting "the unproductive downside of neoliberal individualism." (Behluli 4). Overall, Behluli illustrates the importance of apathetic literature like *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* in highlighting flawed structures and providing a counter tradition to the existing norms of literature.

Behluli's claims are well-founded but never explores how the counter tradition of apathetic literature can highlight the shortcomings of popular feminism. Popular feminist literature and its identity of *girlboss* is alienating and counterproductive, dissociative feminism's apathetic literature provides a reprieve to that. Behluli's definition of apathy is equivalent to dissociation in that they both elucidate a sense of withdrawal; in that sense, apathetic and dissociative feminist literature are often the same, the most poignant difference being presence of female issues. Additionally, Behluli establishes the importance of *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* in highlighting how apathy is not only a response but also a form of protest and subconscious dissent from the flawed structures of our system. This double nature of apathy can be explored in the context of popular feminism, a flawed structure. Recognizing the pitfalls of popular feminism through popular feminist literature and incorporating apathy, e.g dissociation,

into feminism may be a method to actively work against popular feminism. This approach would explain the phenomenon of dissociative feminism on BookTok. Even if the original purpose of Moshfegh's book was to simply serve as a satirical commentary on neoliberal individualism, it has become something more than that, namely, a piece of dissociative feminist cultural capital through its female protagonist that is essentially the antithesis to girlboss, making MYOR&R an emblem of dissent against popular feminism. As Behluli puts it, "Even though *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* is overtly about a privileged white women's experience of dis/affection, her conception as a character who withdraws from the world and sleeps her way into a new reality roots her within an American literary tradition that juxtaposes interpersonal care and political dissent." (Behluli 9). The protagonist, an upper class educated white woman, has the privilege to be apathetic and as a result becomes a lens through which Moshfegh can examine both the society that causes the apathy and the privilege necessary for apathy to occur. Combining Behluli's claims on the role of *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* as a symbol of dissent and its position in the counter tradition of dissociative feminist literature highlights how apathy in feminism e.g dissociative feminism can help work against the flawed structures of popular feminism.

Unfortunately, the identity constructed by dissociative feminism on BookTok is exclusionary. And as a result, BookTok harms feminism because it perpetuates a feminism that is not focused on collective change. Bourdieu's definition of cultural capital "form of accumulation of symbolic capital, the collection of luxury goods attesting the taste and distinction of their owner" (197) establishes it as a foundation for identity-building. But, the identity built on the cultural capital of dissociative feminism is possible only for women who have the privilege to dissociate and avoid pressing issues. Emmeline Clein puts this dissonance best when she said "If

Sally Rooney's skinny precocious Irish beauties are this upset, then certainly I have every right to give up on the world. On the other hand, giving up on progress is perhaps the epitome of white feminism, and promotes a nihilism that is somewhere between unproductive and genuinely dangerous" (Clein 4). In a BookTok video captioned "BOOK RECS for the GIRLIES going thru it #otessamoshfegisbae" by @bronteysbooks, an audio clip from *Little Women* directed by Greta Gerwig plays: "Well, I'm not a poet, I'm just a woman. What are you going to do with your life? Polish up on my other talents and become an ornament to society." alongside a sad piano piece. The books shuffled through are strikingly similar to the previous BookTok with titles like *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* and *Normal People* being featured yet again. Tying back into Clein's quote, Normal People is also centered on an upper class white female protagonist dissociating from her problems and female issues in general. The video begins with the user emulating this signature dissociation, shaking her head passively as the caption "BOOK RECS for the GIRLIES going thru it" floats above her head. The identity is dissociating woman, which is unachievable for certain groups, positing it as exclusionary. The audio of the video is depressing, deeply rooted in sexism, yet all the user does is stare at the camera shaking her head apathetically and point the viewer toward the literature.

BookTok is harmful to feminism because it perpetuates the identification associated with dissociative feminism, which is simultaneously exclusionary and harmful. The popular feminism on BookTok is harmful, but the solution is not dissociative feminism. Idealizing apathetic protagonists and displaying a dismissive attitude to personal and political problems is not productive nor is it helpful for the collective feminist movement. If a feminism movement is centered on just a specific group of privileged women, it is exclusionary and antithetical to the cause of furthering womens' rights. Popular feminism will always be met with counter feminist

practices as long as it operates under the visibility economy. BookTok isn't an agent, but it is a platform that prioritizes visibility, misguiding feminisms in its domains to be centered on the quantifiable metrics like likes, views, and saves. Staying vigilant and critical of these countermovements is essential; just because one is bad doesn't mean the other isn't. As the media becomes ever more present in the development and diffusion of ideologies through influencer culture and performative activism, there will be a lot of counter movements in turn and we must stay vigilant to benefit all women.

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RESEARCH PAPER			
Elements	**C**	**B**	**A**
Thesis & Stakes	Fails to orient readers or provide context for thesis & stakes Fails to present a question/puzzle or motivation for essay Lacking thesis or thesis merely states a fact about its topic	Mostly orients reader to topic. Some context is missing or misplaced Presents underdeveloped, unclear, or unresolved question or 'puzzle' Thesis is unclear, underdeveloped, or descriptive, not arguable	**Skillfully orients reader and provides clear context for thesis & stakes** **Clearly presents and resolves a 'puzzle' or question motivating the essay** **Thesis is clear, fully- developed, complex, and arguable**
[Argument] Evidence & Analysis	Introduces minimal or no concrete evidence from source(s) or evidence that is unrelated to essay's claims Offers limited analysis of evidence. Mainly summarizes or describes text without developing implications Evidence and analysis are absent or unrelated to the essay's claims Fails to consider and respond to any alternate interpretation, point of view, or other counterargument	**Introduces some evidence from source(s) or sometimes introduces evidence that is weak, irrelevant, or insufficient to support claims** **Analysis of evidence is uneven, or implications are often superficial, underdeveloped, or suggestive not demonstrative** **Evidence and analysis mostly support claims, but some paragraphs have issues (redundant digressive, unfocused, etc.)** Develops an alternate interpretation, point of view, or other counterargument that is weak, insignificant, or unsupported and/or does not fully respond to it	**Consistently introduces sufficient, well-chosen, concrete evidence from source(s) to strongly support all claims** **Insightfully analyzes all evidence and consistently clarifies and develops the implications of the evidence it presents** **Effectively uses evidence and analysis to support each paragraph's claim and move the argument forward** **Skillfully develops and responds to a strong alternate interpretation, point of view, or other significant counterargument**
Source Use	Engages minimally with other sources and/or misuses/ misrepresents sources	**Engages with a variety of sources, but some sources are weak, underutilized, or unrelated to arguments**	**Engages fully and thoughtfully with a variety of sources that clearly support and extend author's arguments**
Structure	Argument's progression is nonexistent or unclear Paragraphs jump between unrelated points, repeat claims, or present no claims Argument lacks a discernible beginning, middle, and end, and includes no substantial conclusion	Argument proceeds with some lapses or gaps in logical progression **Paragraphs mostly present one distinct idea that builds on previous claims** Essay's argument may lack a clear beginning, middle, and/or end, and culminates in a conclusion that merits development	**Argument proceeds with a clear, logical, progressive structure** **Each paragraph presents one clear idea that builds on previous claims** **Essay's argument has a clear sense of beginning, middle, and end, and culminates in a well-developed conclusion that extends its premise**

Nimet,

What's impressive here is the array of sources you've engaged (taking on Bordieu is no small feat), the way you've thought carefully about them, and indeed, more generally, the creative, insightful critical thinking at hand. You're thinking deeply and conscientiously not only about what you're seeing online but how it relates to broader paradigms/conversations. The level of your thinking here is *extraordinary*, though I'm not surprised, as that's one of your signature strengths as a writer! I do think, though, that given the complexity of your argument and how much information you get through, you must be mindful about structure and making sure the paragraphs don't get too long and can be broken down a bit more incrementally. Similarly, I think you'll want to be mindful moving forward to ground you excellent thinking in concrete evidence whenever possible so that the big conceptual points you're making are demonstrated fully for readers who can't *see* what you're seeing. In short, I think you've perfectly diagnosed my sense of your writing in your cover letter (which means you're a good reader of your own work): your thinking is exceptional, but some of the elements (namely structure and I'd argue evidence, more so than analysis) merit continued refinement to make your good thinking shine!

With that in mind, here are my two biggest pieces of advice for your future writing:

(1) Structure
I do think there's a generally progressive sense of argument unfolding here, and one that is far stronger than in the initial draft (a good revision). There are, still, though a few points where the connection to previous arguments could be strengthened (particularly toward the end of the essay, after you engage the counterargument). We seem to get a way a bit from the central line of reasoning. It could also be that the structure is there, but the topic sentences/transitions could do more to orient readers to your line of thinking, making the key claim of each paragraph and the connection/bridge to the previous clearer. In addition, as I mention above and in my margin comments, long paragraphs are sometimes difficult for readers to digest. Your ideas are large and complex, which is a good thing, but break them down into smaller chunks to make them clearer for readers.

(2) Argument (Evidence & Analysis)
The other key think that might help crystallize some of your big ideas for readers is more concrete evidence. There are a few strong moments where you analyze concrete ideas; in other cases, the discussion is more general/broad and might be well served by connecting it to a specific example. It's not the case that every single paragraph has to have concrete evidence; in some cases, it will make sense just to elaborate on a source. But you should try to ground your analysis in examples as much as possible (that sort of happens less frequently toward the end of the essay), and I do think there are moments here that would benefit from first offering a specific example then moving into the concrete analysis of it as a way of illuminating your points.

That said, I think you have exceptional potential as a writer and critical thinker. As I've noted, the thoughtfulness you bring to your work really does make you a standout and your drive to improve is not only admirable but will continue to help you hone your already formidable skills. It's clear you're passionate about your writing and about subjects, like feminism, that matter to you; if you can continue to harness that passion and marry it to continued work on these skills, I think your writing will only continue to flourish. I have really enjoyed watching you grow as a writer and thinker in this class and having you as a student. You have a quiet determination, intellect, insight, and motivation that hasn't gone unnoticed!

Grade: A